

Westhampton PSC Building Committee – November 14th, 2019 Meeting Minutes

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Present: Steve H., Stephan W., Phil D., John Z., Laurie S. (PSC Build. Comm.); David Blakesley (Westhampton Highway Department); Chris Sullivan, and John Ings from DiGiorgio Associates Inc. (Architects) – to be referred to here collectively as “DAI”.

Meeting: called to order at 6:04 PM. A quorum was present.

The meeting was primarily a continuation of the previous presentation by DiGiorgio Associates (DAI), an update on their design development, and a discussion on their ideas and the options available to the project.

DAI presented their current “progress prints” with site plans, floor plans, elevations, and perspective drawings (3-D renderings).

There was significant discussion about the site plans and the possible options for access and parking. There is a great deal of interest in getting parking near the entry – or getting the public entry near the parking – but it seems that the site does not lend itself very well to this. Firefighter parking is proposed to be up the hill, where the existing Salt Shed is now located, and beyond that. It was noted that there is plenty of space there for parking, but it is a bit farther from the building and the Turnout Gear locker room than parking along the back side or the Southampton Road side would be.

It was noted that the limited parking that might be available in the “front” of the building, along Stage Road, or along Southampton Road, would likely be taken up with the required “Handicapped Parking” spots. There was discussion of turning radius requirements for Fire Apparatus, and again setback requirements and the need for an “apron” in front of the Apparatus Bays.

It was noted that the site plan work to date was based on the work done by Berkshire _____ for the original Caolo and Bieniek project. It was also noted that the site has been “significantly altered” over the years, from the very beginning in the late 1940s, and that the roadway along Stage Road has also been altered and shifted. The other options for parking, traffic flow, and points of entry to the building will be investigated further.

MOTION was made by John I. to approve the concept of the Site Plan as presented; seconded; passed unan.

Discussion continued as the setback requirements and whether the building could be further shifted in any direction. It was determined that the actual right-of-ways – especially a that along Stage Road – need to be verified and marked out before the Site Plan can be further locked in.

The request was also made to investigate the possibility of adding some or more non-handicapped parking nearer to the main public entry for the building, as this was seen as being a potential problem area.

There was then a presentation by Chris Sullivan (DAI) on the Preliminary (“Progress Print”) Building Plan and the building elevations and perspective drawings. There followed a lengthy discussions on these drawings. There was a lot of questioning about the “look” of the building, with the flat-roof section not viewed very favorably by a number of the Committee Members, as well as the main entry for the public coming in off of Southampton Road, and the public-accessible Meeting Room being seen as being on the “back side” of the building and not near any parking. There was debate over these points, and it seems that there are few if any options that might work. There were convincing arguments made for the design as presented, in terms of making the building “work” within the budgetary and space requirements as established, especially with allowing for the possibility of future second-floor expansion if ever needed. It was agreed that options would be looked into, and that more work needs to be done in “fine tuning” the interior spaces, which DAI was planning on already.

There was (again) concern voiced about the roof pitch and the potential for dumping snow right in front of the garage doors. For structural reasons it has been determined that the configuration of the building is most effective if it is laid out as it is shown, with the roof pitch running the way it is shown. This is because of the need for under-the-slab (sub-floor) connectors to allow the pre-engineered building truss system “work”.

It was noted that with proper (modern) snow-slide prevention hardware on the roof and good insulation, snow slides would be minimized anyway, but DAI is also proposing some snow-melting for the first three or four feet out from the garage doors and apparatus bays. The Fire Department representatives are concerned, but somewhat reluctantly accept these ideas. It was also noted that with the roof orientation as shown, the roof much better lends itself to the installation of PV Solar panels in the future.

Chris S. noted that the roof pitch is proposed to be 2:12 (two feet in twelve feet). It was asked if the pitch could be increased somewhat – say to 4:12 – to gain more headroom for a mechanical mezzanine and possibly a storage or other mezzanine. The questions are if this can be done, and at what cost. There was a great deal of discussion on the concept of a mechanical mezzanine as to how much space is needed, and the impact on the Fire Apparatus Bays. There is very strong sentiment that the mezzanine clear height underneath needs to be at least 8 feet, and preferably 9 feet or more. This will be investigated further.

Garage doors were discussed. The great preference is for “glass doors” – doors with mostly glass panels – primarily for safety, but also for the “look”. But glass doors are notably more expensive than solid insulated panel doors, and are usually somewhat less energy efficient. The difference can be \$3000 to \$4000 per door. A hybrid system, with mostly glass except for maybe the bottom and top panels is an option. But the Fire Department in particular is very much in favor of glass doors. The example of the “new” Easthampton PSC was given.

There were a few changes suggested in the layout of the interior of the building. A few minor tweaks were suggested on the Fire side, a door (or doors) added, some size/space changes. Storage and room sizes are admitted to be “very tight”, trying to fit too much space into too small of a package, but given the constraints, the plan was well received. As far as the Police side, comments were limited, with deference to the Police Department and pending their review; no representatives from the Police Department were able to attend the meeting.

Discussion followed about water supply, water management, run-off management for the site, and the concept of a cistern system for water retention and for use for wash water and sprinklers. It was noted that even if the main water line coming down from the HRHS (the Hampshire Regional High School) can be improved to make it more reliable, there is likely a need for a “back up” well for the possible times when the HRHS line might not be “on-line” or functioning. It was noted that HRHS is not owned by the Town of Westhampton, although HRHS is contracted to supply water to the PSC building (as well as other Town buildings).

Discussion followed on the proposed construction materials. It is proposed to use metal panels for the construction of the pre-engineered portion of the building, the Fire Apparatus bays and Ambulance bay. The panels are used in the well-insulated roof and walls, and they are Kynar-coated for a long service life, and they can be washed with a pressurized hose system. The floors would be epoxy coated, and there was discussion on the epoxy coating to be used. It was noted that a coating that will stand up for a long time to Fire Apparatus parking is required.

Chris S. then explained some more about the thinking on this project, a follow-up on the discussions at the last meeting. This was especially with reference to that delineated in the requirements as spelled out in the preliminary Conceptual Design Development, the Town’s requirements, the requirements by the Departments involved (Police, Fire, and EMS), as well as the legal and “best practice” requirements and needs as spelled out in various design guideline documents, with particular emphasis on the Federal PSC Design Manuals.

It was again noted that given our rather severe space and budgetary limitations, the building as designed can *not* meet *all* of the guidelines, “best practice” requirements, needs and desires of the Departments involved. But it was noted that the building *will* meet all of the actual Code and Regulatory Agency legal requirements.

At this point John Z. again presented another design option drawing, developed as was the last with input from Firefighters and other interested parties with experience in the field and in construction of PSCs. These drawings turned out to be essentially very similar to the drawings presented by DAI at this time, with some floor plan changes and most significantly a roof change to a pitched roof for the whole building. But this group again failed to come up with a plan that would be in the 10,600 square foot range, coming in at around 11,000 square feet. Again, this design was noted to be very much a conceptual sketch, and was presented as such, for discussion and suggestions.

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MOTION: Moved to accept the basic plan layout and exterior conceptual design, including the roof configurations as presented by DAI, pending discussion with and approval by the Police Department. Seconded; passed unan.

DAI noted that at the next meeting they will present more detailed elevations, including interior views, and adjusted and more finalized site and floor plans, and data sheets with more exact information on what will be in – and not in – the project, as well as preliminary costs and projections.

The next meeting was scheduled for November 20th, at 6:00 PM at the Westhampton Town Hall.

Motion to adjourn at 8:22 PM; seconded; passed unan.